

fort in the mobile space. Yes, mobile hardware is playing catchup, at least with last-gen consoles in terms of raw graphics horsepower. The Adreno 430 in Qualcomm's Snapdragon 810 SoC beats out the PS3 and Xbox 360 if you look at raw FLOPS. But there are a lot of other factors at play: pricing, API overheads, and the question of what people actually want from a mobile gaming experience. Gameloft's never been shy about affixing "console-quality" to most of their titles. Is Modern Combat: Blackout a good mobile game? Absolutely. Modern Combat: Blackout is about as close as you can get right now to a AAA shooter experience on mobile.



POKÉMON GO

Pokémon GO is less a game and more a fascinating sociocultural phenomenon. What else could possibly make millennials around the world get up off their rear ends and actually walk around meeting people?

Augmented Reality (AR), the key concept behind Pokémon GO isn't exactly original. Niantic, the game's developer, outed a very similar AR game, Ingress, years ago. Ingress was, and remains, a niche title, but considering that it builds on Ingress's database, one could almost call Pokémon GO a franchise reskin for Niantic's older effort.

Nevertheless, Pokémon GO's tremendous success — the game rakes up nearly one third of all game-generated income in the US — can have significant repercussions on future gaming paradigms. Like it or not, as of right now Pokémon GO is the future, or at least a large part of it.

SAN ANDREAS MOBILE

"Console quality" mobile games have the limitations of mobile hardware to contend with — on the graphics side of



things, as we'd mentioned earlier, mobile GPUs have a raw throughput matching last-gen consoles, but they're incredibly constrained on the CPU side — world building, physics simulation, AI. Older gen console ports however are far more plausible.

Take GTA: San Andreas for example. Setting the last-gen visuals aside, you get the full-fat console experience. San Andreas was a tremendous achievement when it launched in 2004, featuring not one, but three cities to explore and wide swathes of countryside in between. And it's all the more incredible that you can carry that entire world around with you, with improved textures and visual effects to boot.

HER STORY

There was a very brief point of time in the mid-80 when "FMV games" were a craze. This was right after the advent of the Laserdisc and the huge (for the time) amount of storage space the medium offered, but before PCs and consoles became powerful enough to do convincing 3D visuals. FMV games were basically interactive movies in which you got to pick what happened next. Which is about as fun as it sounds. Most people are understandably relieved that that particular trend faded into obscurity. But Her Story does the unthinkable: It somehow manages to create an evocative experience specifically because it's an interactive FMV game.

Her Story works because it's primary mechanic — searching for clues about a murder mystery among a series of disjointed interview clips — works just as one would expect it to in real life — it's remarkably easy to see yourself as a detective hunting for meaning in Hannah Smith's record-

ings, trying to piece a case together, clip by clip. It's a remarkable recycling of a long-dead mechanic—it's FMV gaming finally done right.

VALIANT HEARTS: THE GREAT WAR

At some point of time, even Ubisoft realized that its template-based approach to AAA games was sucking the soul out of its major franchises. While they milked their mainline franchises for all they were worth (and then some), Ubi set up autonomous, smaller scale teams, with the resources and manpower of indie studios to take risk on smaller-scale projects. And while Assassin's Creed: Syndicate puts up a respectably good show (you can't call it awful because it's not; it's just not great), it's Ubi's smaller-scale titles that really take things in new directions.

Rather than looking at WWI in terms of the hypothetical, dull FPSs it would inspire, Valiant Hearts looks at the human aspect of the war. In the end, it's people down there in those trenches. Young men with family, loved ones. Fears and hopes. It explores the humanity of suffering during WWI through an achingly naïve cartoon art-style. Valiant Hearts



explores WWI as a story of innocence lost and is a striking validation of what Ubisoft can accomplish in its games. Though Valiant Hearts is a multi-plat release, the mobile version is a better fit for the game than either the PC or console iterations. There's just something remarkably intimate about interacting with the game's hand-drawn scenes through touch compared to using a controller.

MONUMENT VALLEY

In an old interview with Ustwo, the developers of Monument Valley said